

Army life

The concentration of thousands of newly recruited farm boys in military camps led to outbreaks of disease, initially spread by poor sanitary practices. Disease was just one of the disagreeable aspects of army life. The profanity, drunkenness, gambling, and general immorality were a shock to those who came from orderly homes. Many men who had signed up to defend an ill-defined freedom resented finding themselves subjected to the rigors of a military discipline that denied them liberty of speech and action. But over time, most adapted successfully to the rhythms of military life. A man's regiment became his home, within which he would bond with a buddy and the men he lived and fought alongside. This male bonding was the cement that held the army together and sustained each individual soldier in hardship and combat. Drill and training, capped by the experience of battle itself, completed the transformation of a civilian into a soldier.



Summer campsite

A print shows a Confederate army camp in summer, the soldiers relaxing, playing cards, and cooking. Enslaved Black Americans would have acted as camp servants and laborers.

Lack of necessities